

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES PRESENT

SOLUTION · HOST ONLY

The Last *Countdown*

A Cozy New Year's Eve Murder Mystery Party Game

6-16 PLAYERS

2.5-3 HOURS

PRINTABLE PDF

Timed to end at midnight · 12 character booklets · Letter + A4



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES COZY · NO GORE · NO DRINKING REQUIRED

The solution



WHO DID IT

Devon Ashby, the Gala Party Planner.

How: Devon emptied Ellis's own sleeping drops into Ellis's cocoa at 10:02, carried the blue mug in at 10:05 and stayed until Ellis drifted off. **Why:** Ellis had discovered that Devon billed the town for 400 fireworks but bought only 150, and planned to tell the Mayor tonight. **The trick:** Devon tied the mantel clock's pendulum with favour ribbon and turned the hands back to 9:42, the minute Devon was on stage for the raffle.

The six-step clue chain

#	STEP	PROOF	SOURCE
1	Ellis was given Ellis's own sleeping drops in a mug of cocoa.	The blue mug smells of aniseed, like Ellis's sleeping drops, and the empty drops bottle turns up in Round 3.	E1, E10
2	The stopped clock is a fake: Ellis was alive after 10:00, not harmed at 9:42.	The mantel clock is fully wound, and Ellis winds it at ten sharp every night (Avery Vale, Round 1). Its pendulum was tied still with ribbon, and Emerson Quill heard Ellis speak at 10:05.	E2, E11 · Avery Vale R1 · Emerson Quill R2
3	Only one cup, and one person, reached Ellis after ten.	The kitchen slip orders cocoa in Ellis's blue mug at 10:02. Emerson Quill watched Devon Ashby carry one blue mug in at 10:05 and leave empty-handed at 10:20.	E6 · Emerson Quill R1 + R2
4	Everyone else is accounted for between 10:00 and 10:27.	Avery Vale was up the tower (punch card 9:56 to 10:27). Parker Brightwell, Reese Calloway and Harper Lune were at the rehearsal, photographed at 10:12. Emerson Quill stayed on the corridor bench.	E7, E9 · Avery Vale R3
5	Devon knew about the drops and hid the bottle.	At 7:00 Devon asked Avery what the little brown bottle was (Avery Vale, Round 2). The empty bottle was found in Devon's padlocked supply crate.	E10 · Avery Vale R2
6	Motive, and the staged alibi.	Ellis had found out about Devon's fireworks invoices and planned to tell the Mayor (E8; Parker Brightwell, Round 2). The clock was set to 9:42, the minute Devon stood on stage for the raffle (E3). The ribbon came from the spool Devon kept on the clipboard (Harper Lune, Round 3).	E3, E8, E11 · Parker Brightwell R2 · Harper Lune R3

Why it wasn't anyone else



SUSPECT	WHY THEY LOOKED GUILTY	WHY THEY ARE CLEARED
Avery Vale	Read the diary and was hurt that the keys went to Harper.	Up in the tower 9:56 to 10:27 (E7); the cocoa arrived at 10:05.
Parker Brightwell	Quarrelled with Ellis at 9:30 over the museum plan (E4).	At the toast rehearsal 10:00 to 10:25, in the 10:12 photo (E9).
Reese Calloway	In the workshop 9:40 to 9:47, the very time on the stopped clock.	The clock was faked (E2, E11); Ellis was alive after ten. In the 10:12 photo (E9).
Emerson Quill	Ellis threatened to sue the Ledger; sat right outside the door.	Never entered (Avery saw Emerson on the bench at 9:54 and 10:28); no access to the drops or the crate (E10).
Harper Lune	Carried sleep tablets (E5) and lied about speaking to Ellis.	All seven tablets still there; the mug smelled of Ellis's aniseed drops (E1). Needed Ellis alive to inherit; in the 10:12 photo (E9).
Kit Sterling	Ellis demanded a refund for a fake watch.	Singing at the rehearsal 10:00 to 10:25 (Sage Whitfield).
Sage Whitfield	Behind on rent; resented the waltz credit.	Playing piano for the whole rehearsal, 10:00 to 10:25, in front of everyone.
Rory Penhallow	Feared losing the tower job; stored fireworks against the rules.	In the tower yard with Dakota Fenwick 9:30 to 10:30.
Blair Okafor	Leaked the Wren Tallow papers; Ellis was angry.	At the rehearsal 10:00 to 10:25; never near the kitchen.
Dakota Fenwick	Ellis caught the fireworks stored in the tower.	In the yard with Rory Penhallow 9:30 to 10:30; the one who told Ellis about the missing fireworks.
Marley Ashgrove	Secretly photographed Old Lark's drawings for Reese.	Ran the photo booth all evening; that was at 8:15, when Ellis was well.

Optional characters (16–21) appear here only if they played tonight. The core proof never depends on them.

Script 5 · The reveal



READ ALOUD · SLOWLY, WITH PAUSES

Ballots in, please. Thank you. Larkhaven, the time has come.

The stopped clock said 9:42. It wanted us to believe Ellis fell asleep while Reese Calloway was in the workshop. But Ellis winds that clock at ten every night, and it was fully wound. At 10:05, Emerson Quill heard Ellis say, “Thank you, Devon, you’re a treasure.” Ellis was alive long after 9:42. Someone tied the pendulum with gold ribbon and turned back the hands.

So who reached Ellis after ten? Avery was up the tower; the punch card proves it. The Mayor, Reese and Harper were laughing in the photo booth at 10:12. Emerson never left the bench. Only one cup went into that workshop: a blue mug of cocoa, ordered at 10:02, carried in by one person, who stayed fifteen minutes.

That person asked Avery at 7:00 what the little brown bottle was. That person kept the gold ribbon on their clipboard. That person’s padlocked crate held the empty bottle. And on Ellis’s desk was a letter about 400 fireworks that never arrived.

Devon Ashby. You planned this gala to the minute, and you planned Ellis’s last evening the same way. You chose 9:42 because you were on stage. But a clockmaker’s clock always tells the truth in the end.

Devon, would you like to say a few words? (Let Devon confess.)

READ ALOUD · THE COUNTDOWN CUE · AT 11:59 PM (FAMILY 8:59)

Ellis wanted Old Lark’s keys to bring the town together. So tonight, the keys belong to all of us. Everyone, look at the clock. Ten! Nine! Eight! Seven! Six! Five! Four! Three! Two! One! Happy New Year!

Scoring and awards



Score the ballots

BALLOT LINE	CORRECT ANSWER	POINTS
Who did it?	Devon Ashby	3
How?	Sleeping drops in Ellis's cocoa (the blue mug)	1
Why?	Ellis found out about the fireworks invoices (400 billed, 150 bought)	1
Key clue	Any of E2, E6, E8, E10, E11, or Emerson's sighting at 10:05	1

Award order · 12:00 to 12:05 am

- ◆ **Best Bluffer** (file 34): show of hands. Devon is the favourite, but a great innocent liar can win it.
- ◆ **Best Costume**: show of hands, or let the room cheer.
- ◆ **Best Detective**: highest ballot score. Ties go to whoever handed in first.

IF NOBODY GUESSED

Read the six-step chain on page 2 aloud, one step at a time, and ask the room to shout the evidence number for each step.

THANK YOU

Thank you for hosting The Last Countdown. Happy New Year from Clue & Candle Games!